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Representing London: making and claiming the city

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Michael Keith, Steve Pile and John Solomos 

What does it mean to represent a city? We examine this question through drawing from and seeking to read across two somewhat distinct meanings of representation, stemming from cultural theory and political studies. The reason for approaching representation in this way is an interest in how elected representatives claim the city. Based on interviews with members of the London Assembly, we take a transversal cut across party and geographical lines to analyse the nature and content of their representative claims, identifying two main types: the city as an identity and as a place or a collection of places. The politicians invoke cultural and institutional dimensions of representation and representativeness. The usefulness of employing both senses of representation is that through its representatives, the city—and urban democratic representation—is more than a discrete object or even a multiplicity of viewpoints, but rather a process continually made and remade through practices and claims, even as these slide across scales. These repertoires of representation, of the city as is and as it could be, signal how even from a place of seeming political marginality, the city is open to multiple imagined ideals that are shared and cut across conventional political lines.

Keywords **democracy, governance, politics, vision, imaginaries**

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Introduction

A question about what it means to represent London might provoke distinct responses, depending on how the word representation is understood. Two traditions or approaches stand out. One, rooted in cultural theory, starts by thinking of the role of culture, language and signs and how these connote and denote the meanings of a place. Applied to the city, this entails a range of linguistic devices and tropes, spatial imaginaries and mental maps that make up a multiple range of representations, both symbolic and material. Discussions of urban imaginaries invoke the ways in which the city is conceived through the combination of representations and narratives. Imaginaries are social and spatial constructions that can lead to the formation of collectives, contestations, struggles over and change in the city, through an ensemble of ideas, narratives, myths and images with both material and discursive implications (Taylor 2004). A stress on difference and ensemble underscores the multiplicity of representations of the city that are produced through a wide variety of practices, generating specific and diffuse ideas of the city (Isin 2007; Jazeel 2021); it is always being made and incomplete (McFarlane 2021). Thus, the representation of a city is always a work of *re-presentation*, to follow King (1996).

As significant as this way of conceiving representation is, it runs on a largely parallel track to another set of concerns, in which the word representation has a more literal meaning. Rooted in political theory, governance and administration as well as debates about different forms of democracy, this is representation in the more everyday sense of the word. All cities have some form of governance and, in democracies, elected representatives. Whether and to what extent these officials can or do speak for the city is, inevitably, contested, and subject to differing views about legitimacy, authority and the specific relation between the urban and democracy (Iveson and Tattersall 2023). However, it matters because it casts a different light on urban politics, as the ‘the spectacular dramaturgy of street protest... tends to underplay the necessarily representative dimension of claims-making’ (Barnett 2014, 1626). Nonetheless, the representative space of city government is not merely equivalent to democracy, in view of Purcell’s (2007) question ‘what kind of democracy?’ To which we also add, what kind of city? Across levels and territorialisations there is a tension between, within and across spaces of governance. Both the city and politics are a contested arena of claims between the local state and communities, about what is seen as central and peripheral in the city, as well as disputatious relation to the national state bequeathing or limiting devolution to the city. In looking at levels and layers within democratic structures, such as London government, we aim to go beyond rather triumphalist claims about the potential of city Mayors to explore practices of representation (Barber 2014). Drawing on elected officials who are in office but not really in power, this is a perspective of city politics from the viewpoint of the ‘underlabourers’ of democracy and city politics (cf. Beveridge and Koch 2024). This somewhat overlooked part of the urban governance fabric adds to discussions of the relation of the urban and the democratic.

These two approaches share the general sense of representation as a particular kind of description or portrayal, or as the act of speaking on behalf of

someone. A gap between the cultural and the institutional/political is marked by different theoretical concerns within and across disciplines. Our purpose is not to treat them as dichotomous but rather to show these two forms as *inter-related and co-constitutive*. They each make up an idea of what the city is, and the different conceptions of representation are inter-connected in practice, even if not in theory and analysis. We explore this through engaging with elected politicians in the London Assembly. We chose to focus on this because despite all that is written on and about London, a city with its own unique and contested histories of government and representation, the role of the Assembly in the city is relatively understudied, and not through the lens that we employ here. The Assembly has arguably become somewhat invisible as the Mayor of London is the elected face of the city and the marginal position the members occupy shapes how they see and claim the city. Assembly members (AMs) have some public profile but they operate in an uncertain place between scrutiny and representative roles, while sharing the fate of many elected politicians (including most Members of Parliament (MPs)) in having little name recognition among the general public. We identify and assess several forms of claiming by these representatives. In exploring how they make up the city, we draw upon the culturalist approach, while in considering the claims of representatives, we signal how the institutional is or can also be imaginative. This does not resolve the democratic deficit that forms their institutional environment, though it does open routes to exploring representational practices of the city by elected representatives.

Representation and claims

The idea of representation has become more specialised and narrower because various approaches to it—*aesthetic, cultural, electoral and institutional*—tend to remain apart (Saward 2010). This leads to a gap between the cultural and the institutional uses of the term; while the former can lack insight on the ways in which political ideas and practices are changing and interlinked, the latter can be or become rather administrative or governance oriented. A way forward is to follow Saward's notion about what representation *does*, rather than just what it *is*, either institutionally or culturally. Representation 'is constantly being produced (and perhaps changed or undermined) from a dynamic set of practices, which may or may not be performed well or effectively' (Saward 2020, 4). A stress on the practised, performed and claimed features of representation emphasise its constitutive character in making up claims to represent something or someone, bringing together the electoral and performed sides of representation. Connecting this to elected representatives suggests that they perform 'public identity work' that acts to reproduce representation (Saward 2020, 6). They make claims to be representative rather than merely achieving that by virtue of having been elected. This underscores the active making of representative claims, which need not be limited to elected politicians but can refer to a wider variety of actors and actions. However, for the focus of this article, we limit it to elected politicians to unpack the ways in which they perform, through narration, the act of representing, for instance, in the types

of claims they make, the issues they decide to talk about and the actions—and the space for action—they can take and possess. Although we do see this as associated with the identities of representatives, individually and regarding the parties they belong to, we borrow from Spary (2010) the idea of performative repertoires available to representatives.

To develop the argument and link it to the city, we bring in some additional lines of thinking. One is to redeploy Saward's (2020) discussion of subject and object in representation. The makers of representative claims—elected London politicians, as well as the parties they stand for—convey a particular relationship to an object. In this case the object could be the city, London, though we found they often spoke or thought of the city as located in particular places, while simultaneously claiming to 'know' London as a whole in ways unavailable to local (borough) representatives. Thus, by the city they mean or refer to a part of the city. This indicates that the 'where' of politics is as significant as 'what' is thought of as political (Rodgers, Barnett and Cochrane 2014). The ways that AMs relate 'wholes and parts' inform claims to both speak for and about the city, as they slide across scales unproblematically. So, what is done in the name of representation is a significant element of what the act of representation does. At the same time, when they move from spaces of the city to its infrastructures and institutions (housing, transport, the police), this produces an overlapping but also distinct way in which the city is represented. It appears like an 'assemblage' in which there are a range of ways, levels and spaces involved in a politics of representation, and its representation by politicians (McFarlane 2021).

A second way forward is to connect the idea of representation to urban imaginaries and their social and spatial constructions (Bonakdar and Audirac 2020; Taylor 2004). The ensemble of narratives and images of the city have both material and discursive implications. They are consequential for the ways people live in and experience cities and thus constitute both the idea and the reality (both multiple) of the city (Donald 2011; Isin 2007). The politicians we draw on in this research are likewise the producers and products of such narratives; they help to construct the city in a literal sense (influencing through their speaking position matters such as the built environment and local planning), as well as its lived character, while also at some level 'speaking for' and claiming the city. By centring the (local) state, this approaches the city as a site of democratic claims-making. Looking at this through the narratives of AMs, rather than those with executive powers, we aim to explore the work of 'ordinary' representation.

Finally, we added a specific lens to this research, seeking to draw out their sense of what the city is and could be (cf. Iveson and Tattersall 2023). While the participants had scope to shape the direction of the interview, this occurred in a context motivated by our theoretical and empirical questions about the nature of contemporary London, particularly situating our inquiry to assess how welcoming and inclusive it is as a city (Keith et al. 2024; Liang et al. 2022). Drawing together these various resources we examine ways in which the city is claimed and represented through the representative role. This links the cultural and the institutional domains, casting representation and representativeness in and of the city in a different light. Going beyond claims to the city founded on social movements (Ofer 2017), feminist approaches (Kern 2021) or urbanisation and democratisation (Barnett 2014; Beveridge and Koch 2024), we seek to add

another dimension: how elected representatives do the work of representation, through presenting the city as an identity, as a place or a collection of places, and as enacting welcoming and openness. These are the ways they make and claim the city. We elaborate on these themes after presenting our methods.

Methods and context

In 2022, we approached two-thirds of the Assembly’s 25 members for an interview. Eight interviews were conducted (both online and in-person), aiming to achieve the best cross-sample we could obtain from those who replied. Our sample was approximately in line with party, gender and geographical representation of the Greater London Authority (GLA), i.e. 44% of GLA members are London-wide, while in our sample 50% were London-wide representatives; 52% of members are women, it was 50% in our sample. As our interviewees are public figures they agreed to be named and to have quotes attributed to them personally, except in a few ‘off the record’ remarks that we anonymise. The list of people interviewed and a breakdown of AMs by party and constituency is shown in Table 1. All eight of these members were re-elected in 2024, though Siân Berry subsequently resigned when she became an MP in July 2024.

We chose semi-structured interviews as a method to obtain an in-depth understanding of their viewpoint. The interviews followed a list of five themes—their personal history, the specific policies they were interested in or scrutinised, any specific policy outcomes they could point to, the idea of welcoming and the topic of housing. Analysis of the data occurred in two stages. From an initial review of the recordings, we established five recurrent themes: migration (both from within the UK and international), London’s inclusivity, grounded challenges and London-wide policies. We analysed the transcripts, coding AMs’ comments for the themes suggested by the theoretical framework. We then sorted them according to the types of claims being made by each representative, individually and collectively, looking for common themes and differences among them.

To locate the finding and the themes we briefly sketch London’s legislative and political framework. Democratic governance of the city has historically

Table 1: List of people interviewed.

Assembly member	Party	Area
Marina Ahmad	Labour	Lambeth and Southwark
Shaun Bailey	Conservative	London-wide
Siân Berry	Green	London-wide
Andrew Boff	Conservative	London-wide
Hina Bokhari	Liberal Democrat	London-wide
Anne Clarke	Labour	Barnet and Camden
Unmesh Desai	Labour	Barking & Dagenham, City of London, Newham, Tower Hamlets
Sem Moema	Labour	Hackney, Islington, Waltham Forest

been fraught. London-wide governance was—albeit with fewer powers than in previous iterations—restored in 2000 with the creation of the GLA. New Labour's 1997 vision was that elected city Mayors (sometimes called 'metro Mayors' across England and Wales) would become figureheads, akin to some of the renowned Mayors of cities in the United States. Like some of those places, London has attracted high-profile politicians, such as Ken Livingstone who was displaced by Boris Johnson in 2008. The current Mayor, Sadiq Khan, has been in office since 2016 and was re-elected for a third time in 2024. Over the long *durée* from the London County Council (LCC) to the Greater London Council (GLC) and now the GLA, London has more often raised the scarlet standard with 21 out of 34 leaders being either Progressive or Labour. This is also mirrored in parliamentary London. Over the past 20 years, London has become a clearly 'red' city with sizeable and increasing numbers of its parliamentary seats filled by Labour MPs (Hatherley 2020). Nonetheless, trying to impose a pattern on the administrative and political shape of the city is fraught with exceptions as the metropolis contains a small but somewhat separate city within a city, in the form of the City of London that has its own historic office of the Lord Mayor of London.

The GLA functions as the regional governing body for the Greater London area. The elected Mayor is an executive role but officially, or at least in theory, is but one of two political arms with the GLA. The London Assembly's role is confined to examination of the Mayor's agenda, policies and priorities. Assembly members are democratically elected to a governing body so they have a mandate of sorts, but the structure and ways of operating make them akin to underlabourers. Officially, they are tasked with holding the Mayor to account and representing constituent concerns, through a range of committees and a regular meeting of the whole Assembly. The role of the Assembly has been understudied, perhaps because it has been seen as and become somewhat peripheral. The power (or lack thereof) bestowed on London government was evident from the start of the GLA (Travers 2002), making the position of AMs largely advocacy; it has also become an effective springboard for election to Parliament (Mace and Sitkin 2019; Worthy, Bennister and Stafford 2019). In practice, the Assembly is more effective in holding the Mayor to account when that office holder and most AMs are from different political parties, but less so when they are from the same party. While AMs frequently refer to the London Assembly as the 'Voice of London', only the Mayor is a well-known public figure. In the odd space the AMs occupy they operate in rather different ways, some much more focused on their part of the city, while others use it to raise quasi-national and international issues. The lack of a clear policy remit to the representative role indicates that their performative repertoire is restricted in some respects but wider in others (Spary 2010), for example, it may give them more scope to think and talk in terms of city imaginaries rather than so-called 'bread and butter' issues.

Three claims about the city

Our investigation is based on the assertions of elected officials who can claim to 'represent' the city. What form do their representative claims take? As individual

subjects, as well as public figures and representatives of political parties, what is their relation to the object—the city—they imagine they speak for and to? Representatives are both the producers and products of narratives about the city, imagining it while also shaping, to an extent, the constructed object. By taking a transversal cut across both party lines and geographic constituencies, we identify and set out these claims to representation. We take ‘the city’ to be an imagined environment, rather than a self-evident entity (King 1996), and from that investigate what elected representatives do when they represent. After coding the data thematically (Terry et al. 2017), we arrived at three predominant themes through which AMs speak about and claim the city, as:

- (a) A polis, or people, focusing on who has the right to represent or claim to represent whom; they speak in terms of representing people, who they are as individuals and their own positionalities. These identity elements and personal narratives create a claim that ‘who I am’ matters. However, even as they do this it remains at the level of a claim to ‘just’ representation, suggesting an identification with people and groups sharing the ‘same’ identities. The extent to which this is marked by the lack of structural power they have is something we consider below.
- (b) As a specific place, with varying geographic scales and cohesiveness. From their vantage point as members of the city-wide Assembly they employ a perspective that claims they can see the city as a whole, even though their specific take is not a ‘helicopter’ viewpoint but situated in a localisable area. Yet their location in the city Assembly enables them to claim a city-wide remit that borough-level governance cannot or does not do.
- (c) Claims about what the city could be or become, through small acts of inclusivity or visions of the potential of the city. We treat these as the making and remaking of the city. While (a) and (b) had clearer party political and gender divides, this last theme cut across party lines and geographies to make various aligned or competing claims. In identifying their claims we also suggest what they do not say, for example, about London’s hegemonic status in the nation; as well as how they talk about certain topics, such as housing and diversity, as it ‘makes up’ their vision of the city.

The identity of and identities in the city

The question of who represents whom is one that AMs most readily associate with the issue of representation and their own positionality, but how the multicultural politics of the city was understood was uneven. The representational issue here combines their own identity claims with felt or ascribed group identification, and public performances in acts of representation. Assembly members make claims centred on identity representation, raising the issue of who is allowed to and who is assumed to speak for whom. In a vacuum of political agency do claims to ‘representativeness’ take on more identitarian elements? We noted that who makes claims to identity is uneven across party and gender lines.

Political discussion of representation (as identity representation) is widespread and a common feature of representativeness, particularly in areas like gender and ethnicity where it can be or become controversial when regarded

as identity politics. In wider society this commonly refers to issues such as the presence of women in the board room, or of racialised minorities on screen, or those who hope to break through the 'class ceiling' in education or politics. Such concerns can seem divorced from the city and removed from debates around democracy and democratic governance, but they share the sense that gender and ethnic diversity is a boon in itself. Claims that having more black people in positions of power is simply positive have failed to recognise actual politics. Any continuing belief that the mere presence of minoritised groups or gender diversity must be progressive took a large dent as the make up and policies of leading figures in the 2019–24 UK Conservative government showed (Back et al. 2022). Nevertheless, it is still a common position that informs ideas about and claims to representativeness. While race and gender are paramount, in our interviews we also found other identitarian claims centred on geography and localness that are usually placed outside the realm of identity politics (Richmond and Charnley 2022).

Who the members are individually and how this figures in their capacity to represent was a frequent point that came up in interviews, with Labour and Liberal Democrat members expressing their sense of representation as meaning visibility. In the post-war politics of London, race/ethnicity has often been at the forefront, but there are a host of other and intersecting differences in the city, particularly class, gender and sexuality. Gender and ethnicity were more evident than class when AMs talked about the importance of representation in the governing body of the city. A sense that it must 'look more like London' (Anne Clarke) is a recurring issue in London politics and policy. It shaded over into a question, perhaps even a worry, among some members about their own positionality and its consequences for their capacity to speak for others in advocating certain positions and whether they had the right to do so. Labour and Green Party members used this framing much more than Conservative members, even though of the latter interviewees one is black and one is gay. As this indicates, identity attestations are therefore skewed by political inclination, they signify in quite distinct ways that make some features of group identity (race, gender, sexuality) prominent because they match issues and concerns in the politics of the city. The Conservative representatives who do not stress race and gender identities were correspondingly less likely to see racism and sexism as key issues in the make up of London. Yet, across party political divides, it is notable that class divisions are less common, and then tend to appear through proxy notions, such as culinary diversity. This is significant as a 'missing' identity from the interviewees, at a time when political debates were concerned with the so-called 'left behind', and white working classes, in the wake of Brexit.

For politicians broadly grouped as left/liberal this was expressed in several ways. One member, Marina Ahmad (Labour), felt that more ethnic representation was a way to build an inclusive image of London; her own self-perception overlapped with the wider goal she seeks, so being seen as a representative was the most powerful aspect of her job. She stated:

Having role models is massive, I'm of Bangladeshi heritage. I was speaking at something for parliament, and this young Bangladeshi heritage boy came up to me,

and he didn't want to ask about what I've been saying, he wanted to say how much it meant to him to see me up there. And I was taken aback, but since then I've realised how important that is.

Here the claim to representation is justified by in effect reflecting the cultural group of those who are represented and minoritised. There is more going on though than just a kind of ethnic matching. Ahmad's comment stressed that who she was as an individual was more significant than what she was saying—the latter 'didn't matter', she suggested. This 'not mattering' hints at an awareness of the limited powers of AMs, thus what seems to count is more her heritage than content, as a form of a politics of recognition (Gutmann 1994).

Another member, Hina Bokhari (Liberal Democrat), echoed Ahmad's sentiment, while adding that representative bodies reflecting the cultural identities of the local population served a practical role in opening doors and access into political careers for under-represented communities. She spoke of her experience working for a youth charity for young people from diverse backgrounds who want to be involved in politics. Those young people approached their representatives and felt they were not getting responses or access. From this she concluded:

I need to do more. I stood for the local council, got elected, was totally shocked to find out I was the first Muslim women to get elected in Merton, totally gobsmacking. ... I'm still the only Muslim woman, and got elected again this year, thinking 'Gosh, I can't believe this, there is STILL a problem getting women from ethnic minority backgrounds involved in politics', it's still a big part of my life to increase diversity in politics.

Thus, for both Bokhari and Ahmad, representation was about both being a role model and a pioneer. Once elected they felt they could assist by opening doors for others for whom access to legislative representatives might otherwise remain closed.

As well as seeing diversity as a positive mirror of the city, for these representatives a lack of diversity was both exclusionary and as inhibiting the lived experience of the city. Assembly member Sem Moena (Labour) argued that ethnic representativeness mattered in city-wide agencies such as Transport for London (TfL). For her this was explicitly required to balance the views of dominant groups, such as white men, who are not usually seen as an identity group but whose interests, for Moena, shape policy-making. She specifically referred to the overrepresentation of 'white men who cycle in Lycra' in TfL working groups. She felt that they largely ignored the needs of other cyclists in the city, for example, the fact that most of London's cycling infrastructure are arterial routes commuting from wealthier areas into central London, rather than more local routes. Similarly, in her role as Chair of the Fire, Resilience and Emergency Planning Committee, Clarke (Labour) felt that the consequence of over- and under-representation within the London Fire Brigade (LFB) was damaging to policy-making. In the wake of the Grenfell fire she wanted the LFB to do more to create a community risk management plan involving stakeholders and residents across London. For Clarke the lack of Black and

ethnic minority representativeness leads to gaps in knowledge of how and when fire is used culturally, creating the risk that the Brigade could be unprepared and unresponsive to local community needs at appropriate times.

These attestations of identity representation move across the personal and the political, individual and group identities, and the act and visibility of representing. They cut across the cultural and administrative or institutional representations of the city, combining concerns about legislative and policy priorities, alongside a worry about 'who speaks' [and who is seen to speak] on particular topics, and who they are individually. Across the members we interviewed there was some variation in emphasis on one side or the other. AMs from racially minoritised communities, as well as those who were women, more often made the link between self and political identities, and its impact—both positive and negative—on policy. This burden of representation puts the onus of members from 'under-represented' communities to feel obliged to stand for their ethnic group, they literally do or are placed in the position of doing 'public identity work' (Saward 2010). This can become restrictive if they come to be seen narrowly as a 'black politician', rather than a politician who happens to be black. While minority ethnic representation in governing bodies is not a silver bullet to end institutional discrimination it emerged as an important motivating factor for a few AMs in seeking the position and in exercising their responsibility within the GLA.

For these AMs, the call for greater or proportional minority ethnic and gender representation within legislative bodies was seen as a natural reflection of the city itself. Its touted benefits were being seen as role models, as means of access for others and as aiding city-wide agencies to serve a broader range of local constituencies more effectively. Debates contrasting participatory and deliberative democracy stress differently the importance of identitarian claims on the city. Ethnicity, gender and intersectional demographics are usually more evident and important to the former than the latter. But as the functional structure of the Assembly is straightforwardly neither participatory nor deliberative, identity politics has a selective purchase on members' sense of their own roles. A tension that became evident in the interviews was whether representatives have the right to speak for those whom they do not ethnically or socio-economically represent. This emerged especially in the context of discussing housing activism on estates. For a Labour AM, middle-class leaseholders had benefitted from being able to buy Right to Buy on estates in East London on the open market and then effected a kind of closure by furthering their own interests in preserving green spaces for gardening on estates at the expense of building new infill housing. A Green Party AM suggested that while activists arguing against such developments on estates are often dismissed for being highly educated and middle class, these groups have more time and organising capacity than others, and do speak for more than just their own socio-economic milieu. This type of conflicted representation illustrates the intersection of identity representation among the AMs and to whom they might choose to listen.

Scales of governance and city geographies

The second range of claims we identified and discuss are centred on city geographies, and it is here that the 'London' they speak to or of becomes

more evident. The object they address, the city, appears at different scales and spaces, both in parts (and particular spaces) and seemingly as a singular entity. Of the London Assembly's 25 members some are elected as London-wide representatives, while others represent specific combinations of boroughs. The ways that some boroughs are combined for electoral purposes into quasi-regional blocs is an oddity of electoral geography, creating clusters without a core. For instance, a north-east corner consists of the boroughs of Waltham Forest and Hackney and Islington. While these are neighbouring [although other neighbours are placed elsewhere] they contain a high degree of internal differentiation, as well as across them. These uneven geographies and electoral arrangements create a challenge for representatives: they may talk in terms of having 'a patch' but from one end to another it can be like crossing a country rather than just a part of the city. Almost any of the constituencies reflects this diversity but to take one further example the City and East London constituency that is represented by Labour AM Unmesh Desai stretched from Dagenham which borders Essex to inner-city Bethnal Green bordering the City of London. This understanding views the city as patterned ground, made up of kaleidoscopic parts, matching Beveridge and Koch's (2024, 146) observation of a growing mismatch between 'shifting spatial practices ... and representations of space inscribed in rules and norms of democratic governance'.

Generally, the idea of the city appeared when we prompted them directly (as we discuss in the next section), and they responded by referring to pan-London institutions. There was little difference between members who were regionally elected or as 'London-wide' representatives on this, all of them talked of the city as the patch or party they represented or knew best. Notably, there was no observable sense in which they thought of the whole of London as itself a part. Policing, planning and development, especially housing, were the issues that stood out. All AMs saw policing as a London-wide institutional problem and this stretched across the left-right political divide (though another oddity here is that the Metropolitan Police Service (MPS) which does come under the Mayor is not responsible for the City of London, which has its own police force). Labour and Conservative AMs noted that violence, organised or otherwise, moves across boroughs and separate jurisdictions within the city, so requires a strategic city-level response, particularly in view of concerns about knife crime and gangs in the city. Due to chronic underfunding of local authorities, AMs saw a city-level response as necessary and urgent. The other side of policing, the well-covered issues of racism and sexism as an institutional challenge for the MPS was another area of agreement across party divides, with a common feeling that the Assembly could provide an independent view to enable meaningful reform.

While AMs across parties agreed on the city-wide implications of policing, opinion was split on a London planning strategy implemented or led by the GLA. Conservative AMs Andrew Boff and Shaun Bailey expressed concern that the broad strategic planning and development goals of the Mayor could override local agendas for development. This appeal to local needs was in contrast with all Labour representatives who strongly expressed the need for an over-arching planning authority to produce a strategic development framework for the whole city. They argued this was necessary for critical development infrastructures

that cut across boroughs and could only be realised at the scale of the city. This reflects a key difference across party lines. The Conservatives emphasise 'local' needs, while Labour members take a 'city-wide' view. They see and represent the city in quite distinct ways, one more 'bottom up' and 'patchwork', the other more 'top down'. The scalar divergence here may be a matter of political inclination but it is impossible to separate it from simple political calculation. So, when Johnson was Mayor of London from 2008 to 2016 he was renowned for 'big picture' projects, or follies, that made the city into a 'nincompoopolis' (Murphy 2017). For some, this period paralleled the *grand projets* of Parisian Mayors such as Jacques Chirac (Enright 2023). At that time Conservative AMs went along with Johnson's plans, while Labour members were critical of the nature of the actual projects as well as the specific places they were planned for, i.e. they made claims for local autonomy. While we found that the Conservative representatives tended to emphasise the importance of the borough councils on local issues, they simultaneously agreed the GLA should have more power over London-wide issues, asserting the primacy of city-level decision-making. The difference was in what they saw as a 'city-wide' issue.

Urban development is a key problem for almost all AMs. Some other complications of the representative role came from a few AMs who had two elected positions, serving as both borough councillors and on the London Assembly. This means that conflicting agendas can arise between local and city-wide concerns, in large local planning developments, for instance, that are pushed forward by the Mayor within a city-wide planning framework over fierce local opposition. For example, Desai (Labour) spoke about how as a local councillor he had to manage the fallout of a GLA decision that was locally unpopular. In this situation his main issue was that the local role was primary in addressing concerns about the new development, with as many mitigation measures as possible as the development still moved forward. While the Mayor enjoys some power of planning through strategic development plans for Greater London that can override local planning processes, all holders of the office since 2000 have called for greater and wider powers to shape the city. Housing has become one of the key pressure points (Edwards 2016). The LCC built London's first municipal social housing in 1889 but while it and the successor body, the GLC, had significant jurisdiction over public housing in the city, the GLA does not, with the Mayor relying on working with local boroughs to deliver housing targets, of which only a proportion are what are known as 'affordable' properties, aimed at people on lower and modest incomes.

Conversely, the need for pan-London governance, integration and consistency across the city was more evident from AMs from Liberal Democrat and Labour representatives. For them the role of the GLA, and the Deputy Mayor for Communities especially, was to ensure consistency across boroughs in policy implementation as well as knowledge sharing. In the latter they included the joint London Councils group, a cross-party body made up of the city's 32 borough councils. This too reflects the patchwork nature of London governance and administration that covers a Mayor, an Assembly, local authorities and coordinating bodies across all of them. Hence, even the 'city-state' of London fails to conform to any singular narrative of representative democracy, containing incongruent elements of participatory and deliberative forms (Purcell 2007).

Managing the sustained emergency of the Covid-19 pandemic was one area where AMs saw this coordination as critical. Other pan-London policy issues where the need for coordination was paramount for the AMs were refugee and asylum-seeking support, and the implementation of Low Traffic Neighbourhoods (LTNs). While LTNs are a London-wide initiative, AMs criticise the lack of consistency in implementation across borough borders. These issues and differences underline the way the jigsaw or mosaic nature of London governance is expressed and reflected in its diverse and fragmented geographies.

One issue where all AMs converged was in bemoaning their powerlessness within the GLA itself. The Mayor exercises some executive power in supporting or overturning local decisions on large planning developments, in implementing city-wide public health initiatives such as the London Ultra-Low Emission Zone, and in fundraising for policing through a supplement on local council tax bills. As a scrutiny and advisory body the Assembly inspects the running of city-wide agencies and issues such as policing, transport and fire services, as well as the Mayor's decisions. Assembly members can question these agencies and advise the Mayor but they have no capacity to introduce initiatives or frame new policy proposals. This was most pointed from Boff (Conservative) when he said that the Mayor was 'effectively a planning committee with the membership of one person, himself'. Assembly members from all parties, and speaking from both borough and London-wide positions, expressed concern that they had been democratically elected to represent various constituencies, but felt they had little real power. In other words, urban democracy produces representatives with a built-in deficit.

Making and remaking the city

The semi-structured interviews invited AMs to reflect on the city as an inclusive place. We asked them if they felt the city was welcoming, or how it could become so. Across the board AMs saw London as a city where all could arrive and make a life, though at the same time they each felt there was significant scope for improvement. Their responses combined quite 'nuts and bolts' thoughts, alongside larger ideas about urban infrastructures, voice and visibility, meeting housing needs and responsibility for new arrivals. Analytically we found that this issue led representatives to invoke imaginaries of inclusivity that we see as a claim about how the city can be re-made. Enquiring into whether the city is welcoming leads representatives, perhaps unsurprisingly, to think about new arrivals into the city and how it can or does accommodate them (Huang and Liu 2018; Neis, Meier and Furukawazono 2018). This was evident across all parties, though the linking of migration and housing, although accommodating difference and a sense of London as a lively multicultural city came mainly from the Green Party AM, Siân Berry, articulating a form of cosmopolitanism in the need to acknowledge and accept other viewpoints.

More commonly, a thread across party lines was socio-economic status, though the link to social class was expressed in quite different ways. For Bailey (Conservative), in London 'you are far more likely to have a friend from a different economic [background], or religion, class or social class than most places in the world I've been to or lived in or experienced'. For him this applied across social strata, implying that the perception of London's diversity was variegated even

when living amongst economic diversity. For Labour AMs on the other hand, class was associated mainly with housing type and proximities. For Moena (Labour), a positive effect of Right to Buy was the mix of incomes now present on many estates; for Clarke (Labour), London's haphazard development creates diversity through proximity so that, 'you'll have an HMO [house of multiple occupancy] in one house, single family house next door, block of flats over there, it's the whole thing in every community, you've got well-off in every community and poverty and everything in between'.

All AMs interpreted inclusivity in relation to housing needs, a key pressure point within the city. Clarke (Labour) noted housing as 'basic for the ability to participate in the city, it's fundamental', and Ahmad (Labour) and Bailey (Conservative) shared this view. They all saw stable residence as the foundation on which every other aspect of welcoming is built. Without that it matters little whether one is consulted about new developments, has access to economic opportunities, or feels represented by city-wide agencies. However, there were conflicting expressions about whose and what needs should count, across both party and geographic lines. Bailey argued for accommodating families while multiple Labour AMs stressed total amounts of housing, regardless of household size. Alternatively, Berry (Green) prioritised the quality of outdoor space for existing residents over new housing construction. Across London geographies different representatives produced differing views: Desai, representing East London, said that housing development should move into both East London and satellite communities beyond that; Moena, representing Hackney, argued for infill housing; Berry, representing Camden, wanted to reclaim street space for housing; and Ahmad, representing Southwark and Lambeth, saw the regeneration of existing estates as the main priority.

Labour and Conservative AMs both highlighted London's expensive and weakly regulated housing as a major obstacle to the city being inclusive. While Conservative members sometimes decry the Mayor's housing targets and are not always open to the development of new homes in their parts of London, we found there was a measure of agreement and quite practical focus on how to handle this problem. Two Labour AMs touted the affordability benefit of financially mixed infill development. Similarly, Conservative AM Boff made the case for a GLA-led focus on research into pre-fab housing. Notably in doing so he invoked a city-wide scale and role for the Assembly, pitching this as a practical measure over the (Labour) Mayor's 'obsession with public image and issuing press releases about worthy things, and we just wish he'd get on with solving the problem'. Clarke (Labour) was more concerned with the private rented sector. She advocated a registry of landlords, to hold them accountable for potentially unsafe conditions in rental properties across London. As the Mayor sought sweeping rent control initiatives across the city, Clarke argued for an easily implementable landlord registry coordinated across the city by the GLA. While not solving the problem of high rent, she thought this would diminish the capacity for landlords to employ usurious practices in rent and maintenance.

In contrast to the practical steps above, we found that Green Party AM Berry voiced what could best be described as a vision for the city as a whole. She recognised the challenges of housing but took a bolder view in envisioning how city-wide governance could address this. The Green agenda advocates a car-free

city, including taking over roads and through routes for more green space and homes. They adopt a more radical participatory expression of democracy, with a programme incorporating proposals for planning and development strategies that are entirely community led. For them the city-wide governing body would implement the closure of major roads, using the newly acquired space for participatory ground-up planning initiatives, responsive to the needs of local communities. Berry's ideas see planning as something that should be bottom up, generated from local ideas often ignored in the current planning process across the city. Both Clarke and Berry argued that developer interests too frequently overrode citizen participation, and stressed that better consultations with accountability to local voices. As noted earlier, the question of who is speaking for local communities is not straightforward, especially when residents have conflicting agendas for housing redevelopment, infill or regeneration. Yet all AMs share the idea that dwelling in the city is a key issue that underlines its capacity to be inclusive (Yazici et al. 2023).

New arrivals to the city were the other major facet of city life, but only for the Liberal Democrat, Green and Labour representatives; notably neither of the Conservative AMs brought this up. For those that did, the meaning of taking care of new arrivals varied by representative. Bokhari (Liberal Democrat) said:

You know we've had Brexit for god's sake, we're literally closing the borders, and we can't just say 'London is Open' when we've got a government that is literally stopping that from happening. I know we are welcoming in words, but I don't think we are in action ... If you talk to some of the Afghan and Syrian refugees I talk to, they wouldn't say we're welcoming in this country, they've been stuck in a hostel or a bed sit for over two years now, some of the children haven't been to school, their mental health is just disastrous, and I don't think one of them would say we're welcoming, they're just dropped here and that's it.

This response centres need irrespective of length of stay in the city. Berry (Green) saw the city's role as providing a place where new arrivals could both move and then stay through various life changes, while Bokhari (Liberal Democrat) emphasised the right to work and access to work. For Desai (Labour), it meant creating new housing communities along with supporting infrastructure such as jobs, transport, schools and health services. What we see here is a consensus about London as a city of growth. Only the Green Party AM Berry expressed any reservations about building more and more housing. Across the board, it is notable that there is almost no sense in which these London representatives look beyond London to consider how it relates to regional or even national development. This 'London-centric' perspective is perhaps to be expected from people elected to represent London, while also revealing the position of London as a hegemonic city-state, also reflected in the Mayor's campaign to present it as a global city (Yazici et al. 2023).

Mobility, affordability and accessibility were the other sub-themes that informed ideas of what an inclusive city should be, connecting it to voice and presence in the city. For instance, Bailey (Conservative) argued TfL should not become entirely cashless, even though a cash fare is more expensive than a contactless or Oyster card fare. Despite this, he thought that it mattered to

the relatively small unbanked or elderly minority people. It is interesting that a Conservative AM should voice this in view of the Labour Mayor's oft-repeated appeal to his father's occupation as a bus driver and his initial promise to freeze fares. For Desai, mobility was linked to inclusivity, thus he wanted to see an extension to the hours during which residents over 60 could use their freedom pass on public transport.

Finally, we noted that the Green and Conservative representatives also stressed presence and voice as an element of what the city could be. The purpose of being a representative was to listen to their constituents, so when they talked about what an inclusive city their exemplar was either themselves or how they thought the representative role should function. Voice in city politics was particularly acute for Boff (Conservative) when he said that:

what people get resentful about is when they feel like they the local people aren't involved in the decision making, aren't even being listened to. If you can persuade people that even if they are against something, that their neighbours were for it, people will shrug and say, 'at least I was listened to, I got my day in court'. People want to be heard.

Here the stress on listening and being seen are the cornerstones of democracy and representativeness. While this is not located in a city or urban context, and it could matter to any representative anywhere, it signals an openness to diverse citizens, while acknowledging that representation is about making people feel as if they have been listened to.

How do these varied thoughts and priorities contribute to the making and remaking of the city? As elected representatives, AMs are both the producers and products of narratives of the city. While the themes they articulate are stratified by geography, party politics and gender, their representations do something—they shape the depiction of the city as it is and it could be. The differences across party lines are mainly in the policies and strategies proposed to achieve their vision(s) of the city. Whether they propose practical step-by-step measures or bolder manifestos they each imagine a city that could be or become more inclusive if it enabled mobility, had better housing availability and was better at handling the arrival and settlement of new arrivals. Although piecemeal solutions may seem uninspiring even they help to envision what a city could be, such as a place with more 'joined-up' governance. More idealised visions of the city are harder to realise in the complex political geography of London and its place as part of the UK. However, thinking beyond the 'ways things have always been' is a role and a space that AMs can perform precisely because they are restricted in what they can do by their structural position. Thus, the limited scope that AMs have to implement change limits their representative repertoire in some respects while expanding it in other ways.

Conclusion

We interviewed members of London's democratically elected Assembly as a route to link two ways of approaching the idea of representation—the cultural/

creative and the institutional/administrative. Through analysing the narratives of political representatives we argue that the forms of claiming they make include and encompass both forms of representation. This is perhaps clearest when we prompted them to articulate their sense of the city, as it is and as it could be. We found that representatives from the major parties (Labour and Conservative) tended to identify measures built on actionable agendas, the Green representative produced a bolder but more speculative vision. However, as these representatives operate primarily as advocates they have limited scope to implement their ideas in any direct way. Their representative repertoire is structurally an imaginary. They make the city through an appeal to 'locals', where their connection to a borough or a patch of London creates a space for the articulation of claims, including the sense that representation means visibility and presence to constituents. In the two other forms of claiming identified we noted that identity claims are evident from the liberal and left members more than the right-wing ones, and much more from women than men. All AMs agreed that policy areas such as policing and housing require pan-London governance. Yet this city scale becomes harder to maintain when it comes to planning and various forms of claiming localism and autonomy are invoked. So a patchwork city is mirrored in a patchwork of visions and domains, where the city they speak of can be invoked as both 'whole' and 'part'. The city is both a place and a collection of places and this can shift across issues as well political denominations.

By combining different senses of representation, we followed the argument that it matters more what representation does rather than what it is. Just as the city is emergent rather than fixed in cultural representation, our work indicates elected representatives make up the work of representation by doing it, even as their ways of doing it shift across personal identities, policy issues and scales. In treating representation as a practice we have identified several ways in which it is deployed deliberately to connote and denote what the city is. This research tends, probably inevitably, to emphasise the city as a governmental rather than an everyday category though, as Beveridge and Koch (2024) suggest, this does not have to mean that the democratic potential of the city is vacuous. The formal, institutional politics of the Assembly may lack the liveliness of 'street' politics but our dual use of representation indicates representative repertoires available to elected officials. The structural and institutional context of the Assembly as a city-wide authority gives the members some prominence in the politics of the city, they can deliberate on processes even while they are limited in other ways. The formation of London government was constituted with an institutionalised democratic deficit built in the polity of the city. While this can make politics seem an (empty) performative, the work of representation makes claims of what the city is and what it could be. In attending to this as a practice we see representing London as both an ongoing achievement and an impossible task.

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